



that first team member becomes logical.

But that doesn't mean you get another version of yourself on board. A common sentiment I hear from startups is that "I should hire people who think like me." I understand that this thinking comes from an expectation of aligning your vision with each team member. But vision alignment should not drive you to hire replicas of yourself. Rather, hire for diverse perspectives and backgrounds; that is invaluable. These team members will bring fresh ideas, challenge assumptions, and lead to innovative solutions. When you embrace diversity, you significantly enhance your venture's growth potential, which then obviously leads to increased value.

The same goes for the thought process of hiring for the right skills. While skills are undoubtedly important, building a successful team goes beyond that. Consider factors like cultural fit, shared values, and the ability to collaborate effectively. I understand that when you have just started and hired the first few employees, there is no group, so no culture as such. However, culture is not only about how a group of people behave together. It is also about the principles your business is based on and the values you as a founder want to imbibe in doing business. Ignoring that would likely result in a lack of cohesion, and the team, no matter how small, will struggle to work together.

For early-stage startups, the team plays a significant role. Many investors do recognise that a strong team significantly increases the likelihood of success. Add to that the team's experience, expertise, and track record. A capable and dedicated team attracts more investment, increases the startup's valuation, and makes it more appealing to potential acquirers or partners.

Which roles should you hire first?

For a startup, some roles are more important than others, simply because of cash flow reasons and priorities at each stage.

For a technology-driven startup, developers and a back-end team can be crucial for establishing a solid delivery mechanism. However, in certain scenarios, customer-facing roles might be more important, especially when your company might still be in the validation phase. In that case, development can still be outsourced while you get your own customer success managers in place.

Sales and business development will eventually become a necessity but not at the beginning. The same goes for administrative staff, if you are thinking of any.

Operations and support functions will carry more importance if you are building a service-based business.

A biotech startup may prioritize scientific expertise and research capabilities, while a consumer goods startup may prioritise roles related to product design and branding.

The key here is to identify the critical roles that align with the startup's core objectives, competitive advantage, and market needs.

What to look for?

This point is quite broad, depending on what you are hiring for, at what stage, or what your goal is. Here are some considerations that might come in handy for you.

Depending on your current stage. If you are in the early stages, you are likely focusing on the development of the product. So, technical roles, such as software development or engineering, should take priority. Look for candidates with strong technical skills, problem-solving abilities, and a deep interest in innovation.

However, if the product or ser-

vice is already validated, then focus on scaling. Look for candidates with a proven track record in generating revenue, building partnerships, and driving customer acquisition. An entrepreneurial mindset, strong communication skills, and adaptability are valuable qualities.

If you are already beyond that, you are essentially looking for people with experience in scaling operations, strategic thinking, and leadership capabilities.

Depending on your business goals. If you are in a position where you are hiring for a specific requirement, for example, if your next logical step is reaching out to the international market, you will need people with global market entry and localisation experience.

However, not every hire should be looked at from an immediate need perspective. Consider the long-term potential of each role and candidate. Evaluate their ability to adapt and grow with your venture as it evolves. And look for people who show a commitment to personal and professional development with a continuous learning mindset.

What's more important - qualifications or experience?

This answer can be simpler than you think.

Qualifications are easier to assess. Resumes, interviews, skill assessments, or checking references can all help ascertain them. However, this approach is only relevant if you are hiring team members for roles that require specific technical skills, industry-specific knowledge, or compliance with regulatory requirements.

But sometimes hiring only based on qualifications may overlook other valuable qualities, such as problem-solving abilities, adaptability, cultural fit, and the like.

When it comes to experience, we are talking about someone's past